

LOCAL NEWS

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Library column: When patrons ask 'Which e-book device should I buy?'

George Williams



George Williams Associated Press

The Latah County Library District has been offering e-books for quite some time now through our OverDrive service. And we've written several articles for the Daily News about this service in the past. To use OverDrive, all you have to do is go to the library's catalog at www.valnet.org and click on the link that says "OverDrive Digital Library." Then you can log in to our OverDrive collection with your library card number and your last name and start downloading e-books to your tablet, e-reader or other compatible device. But a question we've never written about is one that we get asked from time to time - "Which device should I buy?"

Unfortunately, there is no easy answer here. When someone asks me this question, my response is almost always "It depends on you." I try to engage the library user in a conversation about their tech-savviness, their goals for their device and their budget. Almost any tablet or e-reader you buy can be used with our OverDrive service, so just about anything you buy is going to work, but that doesn't mean that just any old device is going to be the right one for you.

The first class of device is the simple e-reader. This would include devices like the Kindle Paperwhite and the Nook Simple Touch. These devices are built pretty much for one thing and one thing only - reading. The only thing all of these devices have in common are black and white screens. E-readers work really well in sunlight and bright light, they usually have batteries that can last for days and days between charges, and they are less expensive than other devices. One of the drawbacks with e-readers in relation to our OverDrive service is there are many book publishers who require that you connect your e-reader to a computer in order to borrow library books. So for library users who aren't very tech-savvy, borrowing library books on these devices can be difficult and cumbersome and may require extra software.

The second class of device is the tablet computer. This would include the iPad, the Kindle Fire and any number of Android devices. We're getting to the point where there are just as many brands of tablets as there are brands of automobiles - so much so that I often use car analogies when talking to people about tablets. In my mind the iPad is a Toyota, the Fire is a Ford and the Android devices - well, there are enough variations in the Android world that I usually say that the Android devices are like GM in the '70s. Some of the Androids are

Chevys, some are Buicks and some are Cadillacs, but ultimately they all have the same rectangular GM key for the ignition.

The first big difference between tablets and e-readers is that you can use a tablet to surf the Internet, play games, take pictures, tweet, Facebook, check your email and watch Netflix or Hulu. You can use a tablet to read books from OverDrive, too. On any tablet, all you have to do is download the OverDrive App from your device's app-store and you should be good to read materials from our OverDrive collection. The second big difference is price. Just like cars, the prices can vary from super cheap (less than \$100) to fairly expensive (the iPad Air starts at \$399). The one thing I do caution people about concerning tablets is to make sure that whatever kind you do decide to buy, especially when you're buying a cheap tablet, get one with a good battery.

In the end, just about any new device you buy will probably be compatible with OverDrive, so it's best to shop around, read reviews and buy the one that you think will work best to meet your needs.

George Williams is the access services manager for the Latah County Library District.

